Maj Gen AS Naravane, his son Sanjay, my father and now I—stayed in the Kingsley Block. Strange coincidence.

En route to the IMA, I stopped at Delhi to catch up with my old friends from AFCS days, especially Raju Pendse. I was staying with Veena at their Safdarjung Enclave house. As usual, Veena and I hit it off and she introduced me to some of her friends, Shailaja and Jayshree, from her school days at Carmel Convent. Veena was pursuing an integrated five-year master's in French at Jawaharlal Nehru University, and she introduced me to her university friends, Prerna, Neera and Jyoti. We went out together a few times too, or I would go to the JNU cafeteria in the Old Campus and have tea with them all. We went often to Palika Bazaar in Connaught Place, which was a hep place in the late 1970s–early 1980s with the song 'Noorie' playing incessantly over the loudspeakers, and to the tune of that song, Veena and I fell in love. Once I reached IMA, Veena and I started corresponding regularly.

The one year at the IMA was a whirlwind. Some jokingly call it *Mela* Academy—no one knows what's going on, akin to a country fair. The less charitable go so far as to say that you can put in a mule at one end and get an officer at the other, with no one being any the wiser. This, of course, is not so, but it was something for us cadets to crib about. The most exciting part of being in the IMA was being issued a service rifle for the first time, unlike the drill-purpose (DP) rifles we used to have at the NDA. This rifle was your constant companion, particularly during outdoor exercises and camps. The same rifle was to be used for firing, including the periodic classification firing tests, so one had to look after one's rifle most lovingly. At the end of the third term, GC HV Singh and I stood tied for the best firer and had to go down to the ranges in the Tons Valley for a tiebreaker. HV pipped me to the post and went on to win the General Shrinagesh Trophy for Best Firer.

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